

That they exuded an air of not being equal to the task gave their massive win the shock and awe of an ambush

Message from Maharashtra

- **The first inkling that Shinde was no pushover came when his Sena won seven LS seats. His welfare umbrella opened, and he took home 57 seats in the November assembly poll**
- **Ajit was seen as the weak link in Mahayuti. But he went for a professional rebranding. And emerged in the pink of health, pocketing 41 seats**
- **But Fadnavis topped them both. Conjuring up a rainbow coalition of micro-OBCs and major non-Maratha castes, coaxing RSS into a detente, he wrested 132 seats for BJP—and his old crown**

cal consultant Naresh Arora of Design-Boxed for a rebranding. Ajit's campaign went pink; he adopted a smiling visage in contrast to his usual arrogant, brusque self. He part-owned Ladki Bahin, announcing it in the assembly. A state-wide yatra, seat-specific micro manifestos and door-to-door campaigns ensued. He abjured personal attacks on Pawar Sr. And the BJP got its cadre to fall in line. He ended up winning 41 of 57 seats contested.

But the cat that got the milk? That turned out to be Fadnavis, the one who was nudged by his party bosses to play deputy to a junior, and found his authority truncated further when another deputy CM joined in. His discomfiture was at a peak when Maratha activist Manoj Jarange-Patil lit into him, Fadnavis being seen as a "soft target" due to his Brahmin identity. When the Lok Sabha shock for the BJP was laid at his door, it didn't look like it could reopen too soon. But he squirrelled away at Maharashtra's diverse caste demography, organising a rainbow coalition of micro-OBCs and non-Marathas, apart from established Maratha faces in the Mahayuti. Through the trying times, he kept up his sanguine face. He's even said to have coaxed the RSS into a détente. Cadre and voter activated alike, his party had its best-ever performance—with 132 of the Mahayuti's 230 seats in the 288-member assembly. It was time for the soft-spoken lawyer from Nagpur to redeem a piece of verse he had quoted when his planned return to power was smashed in 2019 by a petulant Uddhav Thackeray: '*Mera paani utarta dekh mere kinaare par ghar mat basaa lena / Main samandar hoon, laut kar wapas aaunga*' (Don't settle on my banks thinking my waters have receded, I am the ocean, I will return). ■